

The Loud Bright Silence

Everyone looking for the *they*. Pointing at the screen, at the boardroom, at the senator, at the foreign capital, at the secret list, at the dynasty, at the cartel, at the cabal. Eyes locked forward. Finger extended. Voice raised.

The wall lit up bright while they pointed.

The fire behind them got fed by a thousand small hands all day long. Theirs included. They didn't notice because they were looking at the wall. Everyone in the cave was looking at the wall. The wall was loud and bright and the loudness sounded like information and the brightness looked like seeing. Nothing was being seen. Everyone was watching the same shape and getting angry at the same villain and the villain was a shadow and the shadow needed the fire and the fire needed feeding and the feeding was the part nobody looked at because nobody was facing the right direction.

There is a *they*. The names are real. The rooms are real. The decisions get made by specific people whose specific choices ruin specific lives. That part is true and naming it matters. But the *they* runs on a fuel only the *we* can supply, and the fuel is attention, and attention is the one thing the *we* gives away for free, all day, every day, to the wall.

Every retweet of the outrage is a log on the fire. Every share of the clip is a log on the fire. Every argument with the cousin at Thanksgiving about the thing the network told you to argue about is a log on the fire. Every hour spent watching the show that hates the other show is a log. Every dollar spent at the store owned by the fund owned by the firm that wrote the policy that ruined the town is a log. Every algorithm fed, every engagement counted, every minute of the morning given to the screen before the body has even had water — log, log, log, log.

The fire grows. The wall gets brighter. The shadows sharpen. The pointing intensifies. The voice raises.

The conversation on the jobsite never happens because nobody's on the jobsite. They're on their phone. The neighbor never gets met because the neighbor's a category now and the category was assigned by the wall. The kid grows up watching the parent watch the wall and learns that the wall is where reality lives, and when the kid gets a wall of their own it's already glowing in the crib.

This is the part that gets missed. The system doesn't need anyone at the controls. It needed someone at the controls in 1789 and someone at the controls in 1917 and someone at the controls in 1955. It doesn't need anyone now. It runs on the *we* facing the wall, and the *we* will face the wall as long as the wall is loud and bright, and the wall will stay loud and bright as long

as the *we* keeps feeding the fire, and the *we* will keep feeding the fire as long as the wall is loud and bright.

The cage has no door because the cage has no walls. The prisoner is the wall. The guard is the prisoner. The key is in the prisoner's hand. The hand is busy.

There's a quiet dark noise underneath all of this. It's the sound of the actual room. The neighbor's actual voice. The kid's actual question. The body's actual hunger. The land's actual weather. The friend who actually called and got sent to voicemail because the wall was loud right then. That noise is always there. It's always been there. It doesn't get louder when you ignore it. It just waits.

What happens when you don't hear it isn't dramatic. Nothing breaks. The marriage doesn't end in a scene. The friendship doesn't end in a fight. The country doesn't fall in a single afternoon. It's slower than that. It's the dimming of every actual thing while the wall gets brighter. It's looking up at fifty and realizing the people you loved became strangers gradually, in the time it took to scroll through a decade. It's a kid who's eighteen and you don't know who they are because every dinner for ten years had the wall on in the background. It's a town you grew up in that doesn't exist anymore and you can't say when it stopped existing because you weren't looking at it. You were looking at the wall.

The *they* didn't take any of that. The *they* couldn't have. The *they* doesn't have hands that long. The *we* gave it away one minute at a time in exchange for the comfort of having a villain to point at, and the villain was always a shadow, and the shadow was always cast by the fire the *we* kept feeding, and the cycle is closed and clean and self-perpetuating and nobody has to be in charge for it to keep running.

This is what calcifies when the quiet dark noise goes unheard. Not chaos. Not collapse. Calcification. A whole population standing in a cave, pointing at a wall, certain they can see, while the room behind them quietly empties of everything that was ever theirs.

The *they* and the *we* aren't two groups. They're two postures. The *they* is whoever is currently feeding the fire and pointing at the wall. The *we* is whoever just turned around. Most people switch positions a hundred times a day without noticing. The question isn't which side you're on. The question is which way you're facing right now. Right now. While reading this. The wall is glowing. The fire is warm. The pointing feels good.

Nothing is stopping you from turning around.

Nothing ever was.